FORGE

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Our goal is simple: to **turn time served into time that serves others**.

Our Purpose:

To build mentors who create a culture of peace, responsibility, and service — modeling the change we want to see in every community.

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Purpose and Mission

FORGE is a peer-led, evidence-based mentorship program designed to build a safer, more stable dorm culture by training men to lead through service, accountability, and conflict reduction. The mission of FORGE is to develop mentors who lead by example, create environments where violence is discouraged, and live the principle of Service Over Self -- turning time served into time that serves others.

FORGE is built around a simple but demanding leadership belief: **leadership begins when individuals stop living only for themselves and take responsibility for building others**. In a correctional environment, this means choosing restraint over reaction, accountability over avoidance, and stability over chaos.

What FORGE Is

FORGE is a structured mentorship model designed to strengthen and support peer-led evidence-based programming. Its primary purpose is to prepare incarcerated individuals to become peer mentors who can safely and responsibly facilitate evidence-based programs in other dorms and housing units. The idea is to spread the virus. Only this virus is to help bring structure and safety to prisons.

Rather than relying on informal influence or personality-driven leadership, FORGE provides structure. Participants are trained to mentor others consistently, reduce conflict before it escalates into violence, model pro-social decision-making, and help establish a dorm culture defined by respect, accountability, and safety.

As described in the FORGE handbook, the program is about **building a new prison experience** -- one where men lead by example, support one another, and prepare to make a positive impact both inside the facility and beyond it.

The Stakeholder Model

FORGE is grounded in the reality that both staff and inmates will recognize: **safety and rehabilitation are not automatic**. They require work, daily choices, consistent expectations, and credible leadership inside housing units.

In the last 6 years, we as inmates have seen violence sky-rocket. Not just murders, but stabbings and fights, many of which are never even reported. Things must change. We all want to go home one day. This includes staff and inmates. Because of this, many of us see that we must take on some of the responsibilities to build our own rehabilitation system to create a safer environment to live in.

We've come to recognize that **we are stakeholders** in this system. Inmates do not want to be incarcerated. But many understand that the conditions they live in can be shaped heavily by peer behavior -- how conflicts are handled, how pressure is applied, and whether violence is encouraged or discouraged. FORGE intends to channels this reality into a structured, accountable role where peer influence is used to reduce harm rather than amplify it. Where we build mentors that can facilitate peer-led rehabilitation programs in all the dorms at Dooly to change the prison experience.

The stakeholder model does not replace staff authority. It complements it by creating a disciplined peer culture that supports order rather than undermines it.

The FORGE Curriculum

FORGE has developed a comprehensive, 36-week curriculum organized into three phases. The program meets three times per week for two-hour sessions -- 108 sessions and approximately 216 hours of structured training in total.

Phase 1: Foundation -- "Know Yourself" (Weeks 1-12) Participants build self-awareness through cognitive behavioral skills, emotional regulation, trauma awareness, conflict resolution, and personal accountability. Before anyone can mentor others, they must first do their own work.

Phase 2: Development -- "Build Others" (Weeks 13-24) Personal growth becomes the ability to help others. Participants learn teaching and facilitation skills, motivational interviewing, simulation-based training with realistic dorm scenarios, and restorative justice practices.

Phase 3: Practicum -- "Lead and Serve" (Weeks 25-36) Training becomes reality. Participants mentor under graduated supervision, co-lead sessions with the next incoming cohort, and work toward formal certification through a review board evaluation.

Each phase has specific gate requirements -- including attendance, written assessments, peer evaluations, staff observations, and demonstrated competency -- that must be met before advancing. The program culminates in a formal certification after completing 60 hours of supervised mentoring and facilitation.

The full curriculum includes over 790 pages of facilitator guides with session-by-session scripts, plus participant workbooks with exercises, reflection prompts, and tracking tools.

Where the Curriculum Comes From

FORGE studied more than 25 successful correctional programs across 8 states and built its curriculum from proven, evidence-based sources:

- **Thinking for a Change (T4C)** -- the National Institute of Corrections' cognitive behavioral curriculum, used widely across U.S. corrections
- **Moral Reconation Therapy (MRT)** -- a cognitive-behavioral system focused on moral reasoning, backed by over 200 published outcome studies
- **Seeking Safety** -- an evidence-based model for trauma awareness that does not require personal disclosure
- **SAMHSA's Trauma-Informed Care Framework** -- providing the overarching principles of safety, trust, peer support, and empowerment
- **GRIP (Guiding Rage Into Power)** -- a California program that informed FORGE's emotional literacy curriculum and normative culture approach
- **MENTOR National Mentoring Partnership** -- providing the elements of effective mentoring practice

The program structure draws from models including PEP (Texas), RSVP (San Francisco), Defy Ventures, and the Oregon Mentors Certification Program.

What the Evidence Shows

The programs FORGE is built on have produced measurable results:

- **GRIP:** 0.5% recidivism among 421 released participants, versus California's 41.9% state average
- **RSVP:** 80% reduction in violent rearrests
- **Defy Ventures:** Less than 10% recidivism; 85% employed within 6 months of release
- **T4C:** 23% recidivism versus 36% for control groups

- **RAND Corporation meta-analysis:** Correctional education participants are 43% less likely to recidivate, and every $1 invested returns $5 in savings

For a detailed breakdown of the curriculum, its sources, and effectiveness data, see the *FORGE Program Overview* document, available at forgementors.org.

How FORGE Works

Leadership Through Service

FORGE defines **leadership as responsibility, not status**. Participants are trained to act in ways that make the dorm safer, the people around them more stable, and the overall environment more manageable.

Leadership in FORGE is demonstrated through daily behavior: **being the example others can follow**, serving the needs of the dorm before personal interests, **protecting the culture from violence and intimidation**, and **passing knowledge forward to others.** This is not **symbolic leadership** -- it is practical, observable, and accountable.

Safety is non-negotiable. Weapons, threats, and violence are not tolerated within the program. Possession of a weapon or promotion of violence results in removal from FORGE, without exception.

Standards That Stabilize Dorm Life

FORGE establishes **clear dorm standards** focused on respect, cleanliness, quiet, property boundaries, and safety. These standards are not about control for its own sake; they are about predictability and stability in a shared living environment.

Participants are taught that **every action** -- how someone speaks, how they handle conflict, how they respect shared space -- **affects everyone else.** When the environment is protected, tension decreases. When tension decreases, both safety and rehabilitation improve.

Conflict Resolution: De-escalation First

A central function of FORGE is teaching mentors how to reduce conflict quickly while preserving dignity. Participants are trained to recognize escalation early and intervene in ways that slow situations down rather than intensify them.

The conflict-resolution process emphasizes posture, tone, facts over assumptions, identifying needs and options, and checking back for resolution. Mentors are trained to avoid behaviors that increase risk, including threats, weapons talk, or claims of gang authority.

When a situation **exceeds the scope of peer intervention** or presents a safety concern, mentors are trained to disengage and refer appropriately. **The goal is stability, not control.**

Simulation-Based Training

A defining feature of FORGE is simulation-based training. Rather than relying solely on discussion, mentors **practice** responding to **realistic scenarios that mirror** the situations they face inside the facility and during reentry preparation.

Simulations mirror common dorm conflicts, manipulation and peer pressure, escalation triggers, ethical decision points, and reentry-related stressors. This approach allows mentors to practice judgment, communication, and restraint in controlled settings, reducing trial-and-error risk.

Trauma-Aware, Not Therapeutic

FORGE recognizes that stress and trauma influence behavior in correctional settings. While FORGE is not a clinical or counseling program, mentors are trained to recognize emotional escalation and respond in ways that avoid provocation or humiliation.

This trauma-aware approach emphasizes dignity and de-escalation without placing mentors in therapeutic roles.

The Self-Sustaining Pipeline

FORGE is designed to renew itself. Certified mentors from each cohort become the facilitators for the next incoming cohort. This creates a permanent infrastructure of trained peer mentors that does not depend on outside facilitators to continue operating. The first cohort is trained by program founders; every cohort after that is trained by the men who came before them.

Role Boundaries and Staff Alignment

FORGE explicitly defines mentor boundaries to protect staff authority and institutional integrity. Mentors do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, override staff decisions, or conceal safety concerns.

When situations involve weapons, threats, or serious escalation, mentors are trained to step back and refer appropriately. Safety always takes priority over peer resolution.

Code of Conduct and Accountability

FORGE operates under a clear Code of Conduct that sets expectations for integrity, service, learning, safety, and community behavior. Violence, intimidation, weapons, and gang signaling are explicitly prohibited.

Accountability is essential to program credibility. When standards are violated, participants are removed to protect the integrity of the program and the safety of the dorm.

Inclusion, Fairness, and Accountability

FORGE recognizes differences in age, background, sentence length, and experience. Leadership is based on conduct, consistency, and accountability -- not status, seniority, or influence.

Participation in FORGE is a responsibility that must be maintained through behavior. Violations result in removal to protect program integrity and facility safety.

Why Staff Should Care

FORGE is designed to support facility safety and operational goals. By training credible peer mentors, the program reduces dorm conflict through early de-escalation, reinforces consistent standards, discourages weapons and intimidation, and strengthens evidence-based programming by providing reliable facilitators.

The intended outcome is a safer, more stable environment **where rehabilitation can actually take root -- benefiting inmates and staff alike**.

Measuring Results

The FORGE program will provide data-rich information on the success of each class and the program alike for evaluating all outcomes, including trends in incidents, mentor participation and completion, program engagement, and qualitative feedback from staff and participants.

Closing Perspective

FORGE is not about control. It is about responsibility.

FORGE is more than a program. It is a disciplined approach to **building a safer culture through responsibility, restraint, and service**. By recognizing that we are **stakeholders** FORGE

strengthens peer leadership, reduces instability, supports evidence-based programming, contributes to safer, more manageable housing units and supports rehabilitation efforts at Dooly State Prison.

Leadership is not granted.

It is forged.

FORGE -- Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment Dooly State Prison -- Unadilla, Georgia A program of the Positive Outreach Development Society, Inc.

For detailed information about the curriculum, evidence base, and program structure, see the FORGE Program Overview document at forgementors.org.